



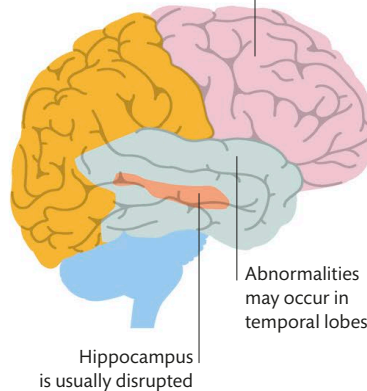
Schizophrenia

Schizophrenia is a mental-health disorder whose symptoms may include delusions and visual or auditory hallucinations. It is a type of psychosis, meaning those affected may not be able to distinguish fantasy from reality.

Schizophrenia can be a difficult disorder to assess. Diagnosis involves examining emotional and cognitive behavior and is confirmed by the presence of two or more symptoms that last longer than 30 days. These include disorganized speech or behavior, catatonia, delusions or hallucinations, and "negative symptoms," such as a lack of emotion or speech.

There are many types of schizophrenia, each with varying symptoms. Paranoid schizophrenics are overly suspicious of others' motives and believe they are being conspired against. A catatonic schizophrenic may withdraw emotionally to the point of seeming to be paralyzed, while disorganized schizophrenia includes flat or inappropriate responses and an inability to complete everyday tasks.

Frontal lobe malfunction leads to hallucinations



Structural abnormalities

The brains of people with schizophrenia show structural difference in specific areas, such as the frontal and temporal lobes. They also contain less gray matter than normal, and this impacts on emotional regulation, motor control, and sensory perception.

DO PEOPLE WITH SCHIZOPHRENIA HAVE A SPLIT PERSONALITY?

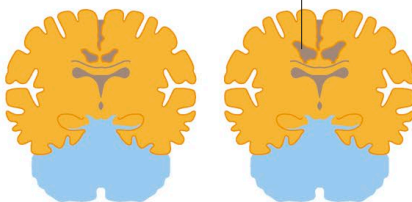
The word schizophrenia means "split mind." People with this disorder do not have multiple personalities but instead are cut off from what is real.

1.1%

THE APPROXIMATE PERCENTAGE OF ADULTS WITH SCHIZOPHRENIA WORLDWIDE



Ventricles enlarged due to brain-tissue reduction



HEALTHY BRAIN

BRAIN WITH SCHIZOPHRENIA

Tissue loss

Some schizophrenia patients have enlarged ventricles (the fluid-filled cavities within the brain) as a result of a reduction in brain tissue in surrounding areas.

CAUSES OF SCHIZOPHRENIA

Despite years of research, the causes of schizophrenia remain unclear. It may be linked to genetics, brain chemistry, life experiences, drug use, prenatal or birth trauma, or a combination of these.



Genetics

About 80 percent of people with schizophrenia show a hereditary predisposition to the disorder. However, genes are not the sole cause, as environmental factors and family history are also considered relevant.



Brain abnormality

MRI studies of the brain show reduced gray matter in several regions, including the prefrontal cortex. This area is important for emotion regulation, decision-making, and complex cognitive tasks such as efficient planning.



Brain chemistry

Two brain chemicals, glutamate and dopamine, are linked to schizophrenia. Elevated dopamine levels may cause hallucinations. Low glutamate levels may trigger psychotic episodes, while high levels damage brain cells.



Environment

A predisposition to developing schizophrenia can be triggered by fetal exposure to a virus, birth trauma, or malnutrition. Environmental triggers include extreme stress, family relationships, or use of mind-altering drugs.